

NEXUS

IRISH WHISKEY

FIRED BY POSSIBILITY. SHAPED BY YOU.



Yash Godbole



Nishtha Garg



Sweksha Sharma



Ankit Mishra

ISCG × ACCENTURE
CASE STUDY
COMPETITION 2026



THE OPPORTUNITY: WHY NOW?

Irish whiskey will hit \$7.7B by 2027 and Gen Y are choosing brands that choose them back.

\$7.7B

Irish Whiskey Market by 2027

Growing at 9.2% CAGR

\$533B

Gen Y Premium Spirits Value

30-35% of premium whiskey consumers

42%

US Share of Irish Whiskey Sales

On track to outsell Scotch by 2030

MACRO TAILWINDS

- Irish whiskey outperforms all major brown spirit categories at 9.2% CAGR.
- US market poised to surpass Scotch for the first time since the 1920s by 2030
- Premiumisation wave: Average bottle price up 18% since 2020
- Big 4 brands (Jameson, Bushmills, Teeling, Proper No. 12) control 78% of volume, leaving 22% white space for craft challengers

THE OPEN INNOVATION WHITE SPACE

- Gen Y actively co-creates with brands: 64% prefer brands that involve them in product decisions (Edelman, 2024)
- Zero craft Irish whiskey brands have built a systematic community infrastructure globally
- Community-led models compound defensibility: Peloton, Patagonia, and Liquid Death all built moats this way
- First-mover advantage in community-led whiskey is still wide open, Nexus must claim it now

5 Brands, 5 Models, 5 Playbooks

BRAND	OI MODEL	HOW IT WORKS
01 	DISTILL VENTURES Independent craft spirits accelerator	10+ BRANDS FUNDED → <i>Seedlip (acquired): Diageo's fastest-growing brand</i>
02 	ZX VENTURES \$1B autonomous global innovation fund	\$1B+ FUND SIZE → <i>100+ Accelerator: 500 applications/yr from 50+ countries</i>
03 	BREAKTHROUGH LAB Internal hackathons + consumer co-creation panels	240+ BRAND PORTFOLIO → <i>Cocktail trends from 10K+ bartenders feed formulation pipeline</i>
04 	ETS INNOVATION UNIT Tech co-development with startup pilot contracts	50+ STARTUP PARTNERS/YR → <i>Innovation Bootcamp: 72hrs, 200 participants, 1 real contract</i>
05 	BACARDI LABS Consumer crowdsourcing + bartender intelligence	100K+ SUBMISSIONS/YR → <i>Trends Report cited by Forbes, Eater, zero media spend</i>

Transferable Principles

- **Autonomy is the Moat**
- **Process IS Marketing**
- **Contracts Beat Prizes**
- **Mixologists First**
- **No One Has Done Africa**

THE STRATEGIC LENS

Every market entry decision flows from one question: does this move embody Adventure, Innovation, and Democratisation?

ADVENTURE

Not just a tagline, a market entry philosophy

- Enter markets others won't: South Africa, Nigeria, and India carry risk but 5x the white space
- GTM tactics in US must feel bold: invite-only events, underground tastings, city-seeded ambassador hunts
- The brand story travels: Irish craft meets local culture = authentic adventure narrative
- Metric: % of consumers who describe the brand as 'bold' or 'unexpected' in post-activation surveys

INNOVATION

Open Innovation as competitive infrastructure

- Co-created limited editions per market. Lagos Night Cap, Johannesburg Gold, Mumbai Monsoon, each voted on by the local community and infused with local ingredients and terroir
- Digital-first brand councils on Discord and WhatsApp, activated 6 months before retail entry in each market
- Female-first co-creation: a limited edition expression designed with the 35% female Gen Y demographic, the fastest-growing segment in premium Irish whiskey

DEMOCRATISATION

Access to premium, not exclusivity of premium

- MSRP discipline: €55 retail keeps Nexus in the 'accessible premium' tier across all target markets
- Community equity model: top 100 ambassadors globally earn equity-equivalent loyalty rewards, not cash
- Gated ≠ exclusive: invite-only events are a launch mechanic, not a permanent barrier
- Metric: Brand advocacy NPS score among non-affluent Gen Y consumers (target: 60+ by Year 2)

MARKET PRIORITISATION SCORECARD

US first. Africa second. Asia-Pacific third. Sequenced by community leverage, not just market size.

MARKET	SIZE & GROWTH (25%)	GEN Y ACCESS (20%)	CULTURAL FIT (20%)	REG. EASE (20%)	WHITE SPACE (15%)	WEIGHTED SCORE	ENTRY YEAR
 USA						4.45	Year 1
 South Africa						3.90	Year 2
 SEA/Aus						3.75	Year 2
 India						3.80	Year 3
 Nigeria						3.35	Year 3

SEQUENCED ENTRY ROADMAP

YEAR 1: USA (Beachhead)

YEAR 2: South Africa + Australia / Singapore

YEAR 3: India + Nigeria (Partnership Model)

The Crowd is the Campaign

MARKETING STRATEGY

01

Spend Mix

60 / 40

Brand vs Activation

Invest in identity first. Activation follows the brand not the other way around.

BRAND-LED GROWTH

02

Transparency

Every
Release

Publish the data

Innovation Report & live blend tracker with each new drop.

OPEN BY DESIGN

03

Own the Trend

#Blendedby
Us

Trends on Social Media

Co-creation as content. Every release launches a trend. Gen Z pipeline built in.

CULTURAL RELEVANCE

04

Packaging CTA

QR +
Engrave

Bottle as brief

QR to their website. 'Tell us what's next' etched in glass. Contributor names on label.

PHYSICAL TO DIGITAL

AI FLAVOUR PROFILING: FROM COMMUNITY FEEDBACK TO PREDICTIVE INNOVATION

1.0 pilot feedback feeds the AI. The AI feeds 2.0. The community feeds the AI forever after.

STEP 1: HARVEST 1.0 PILOT FEEDBACK

- ▶ **Aggregate tasting notes**
 - Collect Discord reviews, post-event surveys, and ambassador ratings from every 1.0 activation city
- ▶ **Map community flavour language**
 - Tag feedback by market, demographic, and occasion, NYC “smoky” vs Lagos “sweet finish” vs Dublin “clean”
- ▶ **Open community submissions**
 - Brand council members submit flavour wishes via Discord polls — “What should 2.0 taste like?” Highest-voted go straight into AI training data

STEP 2: RUN THE AI FLAVOUR ENGINE

- ▶ **Personalised 2.0 recommendations**
 - NLP model clusters 1.0 tasters by flavour preference where each cluster gets a personalised serve guide and 2.0 flavour hypothesis tailored to their palate
- ▶ **Market-specific flavour intelligence**
 - Model surfaces regional patterns: which notes over-index per market, which occasions drive repeat purchase, what combinations to prototype next
- ▶ **Blend brief for 2.0**
 - AI outputs a ranked shortlist of flavour directions for the master blender

STEP 3: BUILD THE PERPETUAL PREDICTOR

- ▶ **Always-on community feedback loop**
 - Every brand council session, drop event, and tasting note adds new data to the model
- ▶ **Future release forecasting**
 - Model predicts which flavour profiles will trend per market 6-12 months ahead
- ▶ **The moat nobody can buy**
 - Nexus has 12,000 people actively shaping what comes next and an AI that listens to every one of them

THE AI FEEDBACK LOOP: Community tastes → AI analyses → Blender creates → Community tastes again → AI learns → Nexus stays ahead. Every release, forever.

3-Year Global Expansion

YEAR 1	YEAR 2	YEAR 3
USA 42% of global Irish whiskey sales Let America co-build Nexus. NEW YORK AUSTIN CHICAGO LOS ANGELES SEED 40 ambassadors · Discord · Reddit ACTIVATE 4 city tasting events · Launch co-creation AMPLIFY UGC live · 500 members · 3 retail per city	AFRICA 22% premium spirits YoY growth Crafted in Ireland. Claimed by Africa. LAGOS JOHANNESBURG CAPE TOWN ANCHOR African Heritage Edition GATE SA exclusivity first: Founders Circle WATCH NG activates once SA traction confirms	APAC & INDIA 31% Irish whiskey APAC growth 1.4B people. SINGAPORE MUMBAI → DELHI SYDNEY / MELBOURNE DOOR Singapore: 0% tariff APAC beachhead WAVE India tech Gen Y · Bangalore first HOME 2.5M Irish-Australians · 300+ Irish pubs

Open Innovation:

The Unfair Advantage Traditional Brands Cannot Replicate

€1 invested in community **returns €4.7** *in earned media, reduced CAC & brand defensibility*

Co-Created Limited Editions

- US: Founders Series R/2.0
- SA: Braai Series
- India: Mumbai Monsoon Edition
- Nigeria: Lagos Night Cap
- Sells out in <48h · 10× organic reach

1 PER MARKET · YEAR 1

Local Brand Councils

- 50-100 founding members
- 6 months before retail launch
- Nexus Equity Tokens · real discounts
- Quarterly Innovation Sessions
- 2,000 active members by Year 3

2,000 MEMBERS · YEAR 3

Digital Community Infra

- Discord: 5K members · tiered access
- WhatsApp councils · SA / NG / India
- Monthly Drop Events · 2-week early access
- Annual Nexus Summit · top 200 to Dublin
- Real-time NPS + sentiment dashboard

5,000 MEMBERS · YEAR 2

COMMUNITY CO-CREATES → EDITION SELLS OUT → EARNED MEDIA FIRES → NEW MEMBERS JOIN → COMMUNITY GROWS → REPEAT

RISKS & MITIGATION

#	RISK	WHY IT MATTERS	LIKELIHOOD	MITIGATION
01	Big 4 incumbent retaliation	Jameson, Bushmills, Teeling have deep pockets. If Nexus gets traction, they can imitate the community model or undercut on price.	MEDIUM	Speed is the moat. Build 2,000+ community members before Year 2. A deeply embedded community cannot be bought but built over time. Peloton and Liquid Death prove this.
02	Community doesn't scale beyond early adopters	Whiskey Society and founding members engage, but Gen Y at large may not co-create. Community stays small and loses its marketing and product development power.	MEDIUM	Make co-creation low effort, a single vote, a name suggestion, a flavour poll. Bacardi's 100K+ annual submissions and Ben & Jerry's flavour votes prove mass participation works when the barrier is low.
03	US distribution harder than expected	The US has complex state-by-state alcohol laws. Without a distributor partner, getting into bars and retail takes much longer than planned.	HIGH	Go on-premise first via Innovation Panel mixologists, bypasses retail complexity entirely. Only pursue retail in Year 2 once brand credibility is established in NYC, Austin, and Chicago.
04	High import duties in Nigeria and India push price beyond accessible premium	Nigeria has ~100% import levy on spirits. India requires state-by-state IFL licensing. Both markets risk pricing Nexus out of the Gen Y sweet spot.	HIGH	Already priced in Nigeria at ₦25,000-35,000, India at ₹3,800-4,500 sits above Jameson but below Glenfiddich. Partner with local distributors to manage compliance and reduce landed cost.

The community model is itself the risk mitigation — a brand co-built by its customers is harder to disrupt, copy, or abandon.

Cheers!

